

Answer Key

Part A: *Pax*, Chapter 7 — Reading Comprehension

1. **B.** Runt — Pax wakes expecting his boy’s scent and finds the vixen’s brother curled against him, snoring.
2. Pax has no interest in tangling with Bristle again, and no interest in anything except getting back to his humans. He nips Runt on the shoulder and warns him off so the young fox returns to his own den.
3. **C.** The plastic soldier — Pax fetches the toy he had cached and drops it as a parting offering.
4. The dens are on a south-facing hillside where tree roots claw at sandy soil; three den entrances are tucked among the roots. Forest rises to the north and west back toward the road, and a wide grassy valley slopes away below. It is safe because the hillside perch leaves approaching predators almost no cover, the line of trees blocks the north winds, and the meadow below smells abundantly of life (food).
5. He is certain his humans will come back for him at that exact spot. Water scents drift past him a hundred times, but he never considers abandoning his post, because leaving might mean missing Peter.
6. Gray says the road was blocked the day before by the “war-sick,” and the crows report that it is now closed. The humans coming from the west are bringing war, and the crows who have seen them describe no youth among them — so Peter is not with them.
7. “False-acting” means humans whose outward behavior hides their real feelings or intentions: turning away a starving neighbor while pretending the larder is empty, feigning indifference to a chosen mate, coaxing a sheep with a soothing voice and then butchering it. Pax remembers **Peter’s father** — his voice faking regret when he pulled Pax from the car, and his full-teeth welcome smile at the woman with the long silver braid while his body was rigid with anger and the room filled with the bitter scent of deception.
8. **B.** A human sickness that spreads chaos and destroys innocent life — Gray compares it to the disease that makes foxes abandon their ways and attack strangers.
9. Peter climbed a tree to move a bird’s nest to safety before his father cut it down; he brought Pax fresh straw on cold days; and he always made sure Pax had food and water before he ate himself.
10. Pax decides to travel south to his home to reach his boy before the war does. Gray offers to come because the war will force his own family to move, so he will use the journey to search for a safer new home.

Part B: *Pax*, Chapter 8 — Reading Comprehension

11. The dreamed sound he loves best — the leather-to-leather smack of a ball in a glove — wakes him smiling. He yelps in shock to find a strange woman standing over him in her barn, tossing *his* ball into *his* glove, with the contents of his pack strewn across the floor.
12. **B.** She rolls up her overalls and reveals a wooden lower leg (solid heart pine, below the knee).

13. She points out that he carries duct tape, garbage bags, a charm bracelet, clothes, food, and water — but no bat. When he says a bat is too heavy to carry, she yanks up her overall leg, stabs the heavy wooden leg down beside him, and asks again; Peter finally admits he doesn't own a bat.
14. A nondisplaced fracture of the fifth metatarsal — a single clean break in the outermost bone of the foot. He is lucky because the break is clean and he is young: about six weeks in a cast and it will heal just fine. Her wooden leg makes the second point — “only a broken bone” is lucky compared with what she lost.
15. **C.** Military medic (“I was a medic. Another life.”).
16. He is not fleeing his grandfather's house. Home for Peter means Pax, so traveling the two hundred miles back to his fox is moving *toward* home, not away from one.
17. That his father chose to go. At thirty-six he is far too old for a draft, which takes eighteen- to twenty-year-olds, so he volunteered. Vola insists Peter start the story with that truth — “That's the rule around here.”
18. The burlap-covered shapes on the wall look like human heads, and the wall is hung with hatchets and scythes, so Peter takes the knife to defend himself in case she means to kill him. After he hands it back and she demands to know why, he learns that the blades are for tending her twenty acres of trees and for her wood-carving — and that while he was suspecting her, she was building him crutches. He is left ashamed.
19. Any two: she gives him cider steeped with willow bark for the pain; she applies an arnica-and-comfrey poultice; she binds the foot with her bandanna and a scarf; she saws, braces, and rubber-wraps a pair of crutches sized to him; she teaches him to swing through rather than hop; she directs him to the gas station a quarter mile down the highway.
20. Nothing between them is settled. Vola insists he cannot travel and must call his grandfather; Peter is just as determined to reach Pax and refuses to go back. Underneath that, the trust question is unresolved — she is offended that he thought her a murderer, he is ashamed of having thought it, and neither apology nor plan is finished when she tells him to go.

Part C: *Pax*, Chapter 9 — Reading Comprehension

21. He smells a strange fox — a loner — and the scent grows stronger as he nears the meadow. The outsider wants Gray's territory, but his display is really for the young vixen's benefit, since Bristle will choose a mate that winter.
22. Gray simply barks to announce his presence. The challenger spins off the rock ledge, blood spraying from his split ear, and bolts down the meadow. Gray's standing is so secure that his reputation alone ends the fight, and his passing presence calms Bristle and Runt “as if he were an unseen hand stroking their backs.”
23. The morning wind came from the west carrying the scent of fire: the war is approaching and the family must move soon. She also notes that the outsider (Pax) smells of humans.
24. Instinct tells him he needs rest and food before a journey that long, and Gray means to leave that same night — so resting costs him nothing and makes the trip possible.

25. Runt is delighted: he bounds over, tumbles into Pax, and drops the toy soldier as an invitation to play. Bristle is hostile: she curls a lip and hisses, swats the toy away, growls, and orders her brother to stay away from the “human-stinker.”
26. He senses that Runt is now in worse trouble because of him. He had often felt that way between his boy and the father, and his strategy then was to disappear so his boy would not take the anger — so he backs away for Runt’s sake.
27. That his humans are not dangerous. Runt is alarmed, as though Pax had issued a challenge, and Bristle answers flatly that *all* humans are dangerous.
28. The cold, howling wind heavy with the threat of snow — the same wind Pax glimpsed once before, which he knows ends in blood on the snow and cold steel jaws.
29. The plastic soldier stands for Peter and for Pax’s bond with him. To Runt it is a treasured plaything and a token of friendship; to Bristle it is human-made proof of danger, which is why she swats it away. The toy makes the chapter’s real argument — can a human thing be trusted? — into something the foxes can fight over. It is also ironic: a toy *soldier* at the center of a quarrel about war.
30. The reader has been given only fragments of Bristle’s memory — howling wind, distressed foxes, steel clamps, blood on snow — and then the chapter cuts off exactly as she bares her fangs and begins. We know the story will be terrible but not what happened, so the withheld ending pulls us into the next chapter.

Part D: Parts of Speech

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|-----------------|-----------------|
| 1. adverb | 11. adjective |
| 2. preposition | 12. pronoun |
| 3. noun | 13. noun |
| 4. adjective | 14. verb |
| 5. conjunction | 15. adverb |
| 6. pronoun | 16. preposition |
| 7. verb | 17. conjunction |
| 8. adverb | 18. adjective |
| 9. preposition | 19. pronoun |
| 10. conjunction | 20. conjunction |

Part E: Subject and Predicate

CS = complete subject, *CP* = complete predicate, *SS* = simple subject, *SP* = simple predicate.

1. CS: The exhausted fox CP: waited beside the silent road SS: fox SP: waited

2. CS: Gray and Pax CP: followed the stream through the woods SS: Gray, Pax (compound)
SP: followed
3. CS: a cold, clear stream CP: Beneath the road rushed SS: stream SP: rushed (inverted order)
4. CS: The distant scent of fire CP: worried the foxes SS: scent SP: worried
5. CS: Vola's sharp questions CP: exposed Peter's story SS: questions SP: exposed
6. CS: The former medic CP: examined the swollen foot SS: medic SP: examined
7. CS: several carving tools CP: On the barn wall hung SS: tools SP: hung (inverted order)
8. CS: Peter CP: accepted the crutches and approached the door SS: Peter SP: accepted, approached (compound)
9. CS: Bristle and her brother CP: argued over the toy soldier SS: Bristle, brother (compound)
SP: argued
10. CS: A rough-furred stranger CP: challenged Gray SS: stranger SP: challenged
11. CS: the smell of smoke CP: From the western forest came SS: smell SP: came (inverted order)
12. CS: The pregnant vixen CP: shared an urgent warning SS: vixen SP: shared
13. CS: Runt CP: retrieved the toy and displayed it proudly SS: Runt SP: retrieved, displayed (compound)
14. CS: The memory of steel traps CP: terrified Bristle SS: memory SP: terrified
15. CS: Pax's loyalty to Peter CP: guided every decision SS: loyalty SP: guided

Part F: Subject–Verb Agreement

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| 1. warns | 9. carries |
| 2. needs | 10. look |
| 3. travel | 11. senses |
| 4. stop | 12. seems |
| 5. are | 13. come |
| 6. is | 14. flows |
| 7. helps | 15. make |
| 8. enjoy | |

Notes: 1, 7, 10, and 14 turn on the true subject (*scent, pair, tools, some* = some water), not the noun nearest the verb. In 4 and 9, “neither/nor” and “either/or” agree with the *nearer* subject. In 12, *twenty miles* is a single distance, so it takes a singular verb.

Rewrites:

16. The pack of supplies **was** scattered across the floor.
17. Neither Peter nor Vola **trusts** the other completely.
18. There **are** several tools above the workbench.
19. Every one of the foxes **faces** danger from the war.
20. The stories carried by the crows **are** frightening.